

GCSE English Language Structure Analysis

A free step by step guide for students and parents

Learn to explain how a writer guides your attention, reveals information and changes your expectations. This guide includes two original extracts, an annotated model, independent practice and full answers.

The question behind structure analysis

What does the writer show us, in what order, and why does that order matter?

A practical way to read

- **1. Find the task.** Identify the effect or idea the question asks you to explore. Follow its instructions about which part of the text to use.
- **2. Map the focus.** Note what we notice first, where attention moves and what we are left with at the end.
- **3. Track the change.** Look for a reveal, a delay, a contrast, a change of time or perspective, or a shift in pace.
- **4. Explain the effect.** Say what we now know, expect or question, and support it with a precise reference.
- **5. Ask why here.** Explain why placing this detail at this point changes the reader's experience.

Using this guide with your exam board

The reading skills apply broadly, but question numbers, marks and instructions vary. For **AQA GCSE English Language 8700, Paper 1 Question 3**, the 2026 format is an **8-mark** structure question about the **whole source** and a **specified effect**. Read the actual question: the effect is not always tension. Official sources are linked on page 8.

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Follow changes rather than collecting labels

A term is useful when it helps you explain a choice. You do not need to find every technique in every extract. Start with what the text actually does.

Focus and sequence

Focus is what receives our attention. A writer might move from a busy street to one doorway, then to a hand behind it. That narrowing focus can reveal a possible threat gradually. **Sequence** is the order of information: an unexplained noise before a reveal creates a different experience from naming its source straight away.

Shifts and contrasts

Track what changes: place, time, subject, mood or activity. Name the movement precisely, such as from public celebration to one person's private disappointment. Explain how the second moment changes our view of the first. A shift does not automatically create tension.

Perspective and knowledge

Ask whose experience we follow and what they can know. A first-person account may limit us to one character's discoveries; a third-person narrator may also stay close to one character. A focus shift to a door is not necessarily a change of narrator or viewpoint. Explain what information becomes available or remains hidden.

Time and pace

A flashback moves to an earlier event; it can supply context at a revealing moment. Pace concerns how quickly the account moves through events. A pause for observation can delay an outcome; a rapid sequence of actions can make it feel imminent. Sentence length alone does not prove either effect.

Openings and endings

Ask what expectation the opening establishes and whether the ending fulfils, overturns or leaves it unresolved. A return to an opening image may highlight change. For an extract, discuss the ending of the extract; do not invent what happens later in the complete story.

Language or structure

Language analysis can explore the associations of a repeated word. Structure analysis can explore where the repetition appears, what happens between its appearances and how its meaning changes. The same detail can support either approach; your explanation decides the focus.

A useful chain: choice + precise reference + what changes for the reader + why the placement matters. This is a thinking aid, not a compulsory sentence formula.

The workshop

Original fictional extract written for this guide. The numbers identify paragraphs, not exam line numbers. Read once for meaning, then again to trace the order of information.

1 At closing time, the museum courtyard lay empty. I crossed it with the last set of keys, passing dark windows and chairs stacked beneath the awning. At the far end, the workshop door stood open. I was certain I had locked it.

2 Inside, nothing seemed disturbed. The long bench was clear. Brushes stood in their jar. Even the old clock above the sink ticked with its usual patience. I listened. Beyond the partition, something scraped across the floor.

3 That morning, Mara had shown me the new display cases. She had checked each catch twice, then handed me the keys. “Whatever happens, keep that workshop shut,” she had said. She had been called away before I could ask why.

4 I stepped towards the partition. My torch caught a fallen cloth, a chair on its side and a trail of muddy marks. I stopped to study them. They disappeared beneath a canvas cover. For a moment, the only movement came from the second hand of the clock.

5 The cover lifted. I backed into the bench. A small shape shot past my feet, struck the door and turned. Two bright eyes faced me. Then came a thin, indignant meow.

6 Mara appeared in the doorway carrying an empty cat basket. “I meant keep him in,” she said. I lowered the torch. Above the sink, the clock ticked on while she coaxed the escaped cat into its basket. I left the door open for her.

Practice question

How does the arrangement of information in this extract build and then release tension?

Before you turn the page: identify the first disturbance, the moment when the writer delays an explanation, and the point when the reader can reinterpret the danger.

A short map: ordinary closing routine → unexplained noise → earlier warning → slow inspection → sudden movement → harmless explanation.

An annotated model response

This is one possible interpretation of The workshop. It is a teaching model, not an examiner-marked answer or a promise of a particular score.

Opening and early uncertainty

The writer begins with an ordinary closing routine before narrowing the focus to the open workshop door. The narrator's certainty that it was locked makes this detail disrupt the calm opening, so the reader begins to suspect an unexpected visitor. The next paragraph briefly surveys familiar objects, delaying an explanation, before the scrape beyond the partition renews that uncertainty. Because we discover these details through the narrator's first-person account, we cannot yet see what is hidden and share the wait for an answer.

Annotation: the opening is connected to the later disturbance; the effect is explained through what the reader can and cannot know.

Delay and escalation

Instead of revealing the source of the noise, the writer moves back to Mara's warning that morning. This flashback gives the open door greater significance just when the reader is already looking for an explanation. As the reason for the warning was never given, it increases uncertainty rather than resolving it. When the account returns to the workshop, the narrator pauses to inspect the muddy marks and the cover. This slows the approach to the hidden creature, making the next movement feel anticipated. The burst of actions in paragraph 5 then converts waiting into an immediate encounter.

Annotation: the explanation follows the flashback, the return to the present and the change in pace, showing why each is placed here.

Reversal at the ending

The meow finally identifies the creature and begins to release the tension. Mara's explanation in the last paragraph then changes how we understand her earlier warning: it concerned keeping a cat inside, rather than keeping an unknown danger out. Delaying that explanation allows the reader to share the narrator's mistaken suspicion first. The return to the clock now accompanies a calm, practical task, whereas its earlier appearance marked an anxious pause. The narrator leaving the door open also reverses the opening concern about the unlocked door, reinforcing the movement from unease to relief.

Annotation: the ending is linked back to the warning, clock and door, explaining how earlier details acquire a different meaning.

Try this: underline a sentence that explains why a detail appears at that point. Then find where the model connects the ending to something earlier. Those links turn observations into analysis.

Useful flexibility: these three paragraphs suit this extract. Another text may be better discussed through two important shifts or a sustained contrast. Choose the organisation that lets you explain its significant choices.

The rehearsal

A second original fictional extract. Make notes on paper or in a separate document before reading the answers on page 6.

- 1** From the back of the hall, the rehearsal seemed to be over. The chairs stood in straight rows. A single pool of light lay on the stage. In the centre, a violin waited on its stand. Lena had come only to switch off the lights.
- 2** She walked down the aisle, collecting abandoned programmes. Then three notes sounded behind the curtain. She stopped. The sound ended before she could decide which instrument had made it.
- 3** For a moment she was back at last winter's concert, counting those same three notes under her breath. Her sister had used them before every performance, a private signal that she was ready. But her sister was now working abroad.
- 4** Lena called her name anyway. Nobody replied. She reached the steps, set the programmes down, then picked them up again. Behind the curtain, a chair creaked.
- 5** The three notes sounded once more. This time Lena pulled the curtain aside. A music player rested on a chair; beside it lay an envelope with her name on it. She pressed the stop button. The hall fell silent.
- 6** She turned the envelope over. On the back, in her sister's handwriting, were five words: Wait until the audience leaves. Far above the empty seats, the balcony door clicked shut.

Practice question

How does the order in which information is revealed create mystery in this extract?

Plan first. What seems settled at the start? What does the memory explain, and what new question does it create? Which mystery is answered at the curtain? What remains uncertain at the end?

Then write. Develop your most useful points with precise references and explanations of why the order matters. For a short practice session, try two or three connected paragraphs. These mini-extracts are skill practice, not full-length mock exam sources.

Answers for The rehearsal

The planning questions

- **At the start:** the room seems ready to be closed. The sound interrupts this settled impression.
- **The memory:** the notes are associated with Lena's sister. Her absence abroad makes their recurrence harder to explain.
- **At the curtain:** the music player accounts for the sound. It does not tell us who placed the player and envelope there or why.
- **At the end:** the message and closing door suggest that more needs explaining. The text does not establish who closed the door.

A possible response

The writer first presents an apparently finished rehearsal and Lena's routine job of turning off the lights. This establishes an expectation that nothing further will happen. The unexplained notes then interrupt that expectation. We follow Lena's discovery without being shown behind the curtain, so the source of the sound remains hidden and the reader begins to question who or what might still be in the hall.

The account then shifts to Lena's memory of her sister playing the same notes. This gives the sound a personal connection, but placing the information that her sister is abroad immediately afterwards makes that connection puzzling. The memory therefore supplies one explanation while raising another question. Returning to the present, the writer delays the reveal through the unanswered call and Lena's hesitation over the programmes. The repeated notes bring our attention back to the unresolved sound and prompt the eventual search behind the curtain.

The music player answers the immediate question about the sound, but the nearby envelope introduces a new uncertainty about who arranged this. The final paragraph gives us the sister's written instruction without explaining how it reached the hall. Ending on the balcony door clicking shut shifts attention away from the discovered objects to a possible unseen presence elsewhere. The extract moves from a seemingly empty space to evidence of unexplained activity, leaving the wider mystery open even after the first puzzle has been partly solved.

Other readings can work

You could explore how the focus moves from the whole hall to the curtain, then to the envelope, before widening towards the balcony. Support the effect with the details, and avoid claiming that the sister must be present.

Upgrade the explanation

Compare each starting point with the developed explanation. The improvement comes from reasoning about a particular passage, not adding impressive terminology.

From retelling to a structural choice

Starting point: “Lena hears music and then remembers her sister.”

Developed: “The writer inserts the memory after the unexplained music, so it offers a possible identity for the musician before the detail about the sister being abroad makes that explanation uncertain.”

From a label to a changing effect

Starting point: “The writer uses repetition to create tension.”

Developed: “The clock returns during the slow inspection and again after the cat is identified. Its placement connects an anxious pause with an ordinary task, highlighting how the tension has eased.”

From a general claim to a supported inference

Starting point: “Short sentences always speed up the text.”

Developed: “In paragraph 5 of The workshop, several actions follow quickly after the long inspection. This change from watching to reacting makes the hidden creature's appearance feel sudden.”

Two quick checks

1. A learner writes, “The writer changes perspective when Lena looks up at the balcony.” What needs checking?
2. A learner writes, “The music player resolves the mystery completely.” How could they improve this?

Answers

1. First check what is actually stated: the extract ends with the sound of a door above the seats; it does not say Lena looks up. Attention shifts to the balcony, but there is no established change of viewpoint. A focus shift is the safer term here.
2. The player explains the sound, while the envelope and closing door raise further questions. A more accurate response distinguishes this local explanation from the unresolved ending of the extract.

A final test of precision

Replace “This makes the reader want to read on” with the specific question or expectation the writer creates. Then explain which choice creates it at this point.

A final check before you finish

- **Task:** have I answered the effect or idea the question actually names?
- **Evidence:** can the reader locate each choice through my quotation or precise reference?
- **Movement:** have I explained what changes, stays the same, is delayed or is revealed?
- **Effect:** have I said what this leads the reader to know, expect or question?
- **Placement:** have I explained why the detail appears here and linked relevant parts?
- **Accuracy:** have I avoided invented events, automatic effects and unsupported technique labels?

A short revision routine

Read an unfamiliar extract and write a one-line map of its changing focus. Choose one important change and explain why it happens there. Compare the ending with the opening. Finally, check whether your explanation fits the exact wording of the question. Repeating this with different texts is more useful than memorising one model.

For parents and carers

You do not need a list of technical terms. Ask: “What did you think was happening at first?”, “What changed your mind?” and “Which detail did the writer make you wait for?” Invite your child to point to the passage and explain the order. Use the answers in this guide to discuss the reasoning rather than assign an exam grade.

Exam information and sources

The AQA note on page 1 was checked on 3 October 2026 against the official resources below. This independent guide is not produced, approved or endorsed by AQA. Always follow your own exam paper and your teacher's guidance.

[AQA GCSE English Language updates for 2026](#)

[AQA Paper 1 answers and commentaries from 2026](#) (Question 3, pages 8 to 14)

Want help applying the method

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